

Jonathan Selvaraj

jonathan.selvaraj@thehindu.co.in

Even as age-group results in sport go, there was something particularly unique about the promise behind Omik Bhakkad's **(right)** silver medal in the individual elimination competition at the Indian Under-13 Archery Nationals held in Guntur, Andhra Pradesh, on March 31 this year. It was not so much about the 13-year-old Omik, who also won bronze in the ranking round with a score of 354/360, as much as about the compound bow he shot with.

While competitors around him used imported Hoyt, Sanlida and PSE bows, Omik's metallic neon green instrument was a Tej 28, built by Indian company Imaxx Sports, the country's only domestic manufacturer of compound bows.

"Omik's medals are an important milestone in our journey to manufacture India's first compound bow," says Girish Venkatasubban, proprietor of Imaxx Sports.

Girish says he set out to manufacture India's first indigenous compound bow three years ago. At the time, he approached the project as a technical challenge he was confident of solving.

"Just how hard could it be to make one? It's not exactly rocket science," he remembers thinking.

The 49-year-old is no stranger to solving some of India's toughest engineering problems and is more than familiar with rockets. Girish is also the managing director of Microfine Bushings Pvt Ltd, a precision manufacturing company based in Chennai. Established by his father in 1981, the company has built indigenous machinery for India's military and space programmes: launch vehicle umbilicals (the mechanism that separates the booster from the main vehicle), power packs for the Army's heavy tanks, guidance fins for rockets and supersonic missiles deployed by India during Operation Sindoor last year.

Now, add India's first range of compound bows to that portfolio.

It is an unlikely journey, one that began in 2023 when Girish turned to his nine-year-old son Vishwa and told him he needed to learn a sport and a craft.

"Archery," came the answer.

Girish remembers being mildly surprised. He had assumed his son would pick cricket or football, not something as niche as archery. Still, he searched for a nearby academy, found one and enrolled him. At first, it was routine: practice sessions with basic equipment, the kind of entry-level recurve bows available at any multi-sport goods store. But a few weeks later, the coach suggested it was time for an upgrade if Vishwa was going to take the sport seriously.

There was the option of buying a recurve or a



compound bow. Recurve bows are unforgiving and harder to draw, especially for young archers, so Girish's son was advised to take up compound archery, where pulleys attached to the limbs make it easier to hold the arrow at full draw.

Girish paid the money — about Rs. 1,35,000 for a bow from Chinese manufacturer Sanlida — without much thought. It seemed expensive, but he assumed that was the cost of importing specialised equipment.

Then he waited.

Weeks passed. Then more weeks. There was always a reason. The equipment had not arrived yet. It was being shipped. It was stuck somewhere in the supply chain.

"Eventually, I had to ask what the reason was behind the delay. That's when the coach told me that none of the bows used by Indian archers was made in India. They came from either China or the USA. I also found out later, when I compared the manufacturer's selling price with what I was paying, that I was paying several times the actual cost," he says.

For most people, that would have been the end of the matter: an acceptance that importing sports equipment is expensive. There was a kind of recurve bow, known as the Manipur bow and made out of bamboo, that was built locally, but nothing similar existed in compound archery.

India is considered one of the global powerhouses of compound archery. Across the last two World Championships, Indian archers have won five medals, including four golds in